

HEMANT MISHRA

women for their next-level roles; and Decode, which provides opportunities for engaging conversations between women staff and their managers.

Women employees at HCL Tech are exposed to top-notch learning material that includes Harvard Business School case studies. "Our staff can choose whichever course they want, at their own pace," says Chandini Kamal, global head, DEI. "This helps women in other time zones learn as per their choice of time, say, after finishing all household chores." In addition to providing learning material, peer coaching too is offered, so that the staff stays abreast of the latest developments in their fields.

The company also has an AI-driven, structured mentoring portal where staff can register and outline their aspirations, following which they are connected with the right mentor, who is, typically, a senior leader, say, someone of the level of vice president or higher. Those who get trained and become leaders are then encouraged to mentor the younger staff in turn. Programmes that have heavy technical content, like Prelude, aim to help women become "solution architects", for which HCL works with training academies. "We have seen amazing retention rate in this particular cohort," says Kamal. "We also track their growth in their journeys and whether they have received the right change of role."

"Firms will fail to fulfil their DEI agenda if the leadership is not committed to the idea and build a culture of allyship and advocacy"

Saundarya Rajesh, *Founder-president, Avtar Group*

The firm also has networking and advocacy platforms where women leaders from among HCL Tech's clients are invited to address the company's women staff, the idea being to share the success stories of women leaders. "Women staff could be limited by their own inhibitions because they come from different backgrounds. These sessions help them look up to their role models and be inspired," says Kamal.

Deloitte does something similar. To help women manage the challenges they face at various life and professional stages, the company has developed tailored outreach programmes, says Saraswathi Kasturirangan, partner at Deloitte India. "The idea is that women, regardless of their position, have the opportunity to connect with seniors who they can relate to and discuss their challenges with, providing them with a push in their journey." The company has a programme called DRIWE , or Deloitte Redefines Impact for Women Excellence, for women at the middle management level, where a women-only cohort of Deloitte's senior leaders imparts practical guidance on managing home and work, and on prioritising tasks. At the senior manager and director levels, there is a sponsorship programme in which a senior partner adopts a woman leader to prepare her for the board position. It is not lost on Kasturirangan how important that is, since despite the fact that Deloitte boasts an overall diversity rate of 38 per cent, women in leadership positions constitute only 16 per cent of the workforce. "There is a need to move the needle there."

For, as Rajesh of Avtar Group says, "Unless the leadership is committed to gender diversity and focuses on building a culture of allyship and advocacy within the firm, companies will find it difficult to fulfil their diversity agenda". At the same time, they need to guard against adopting diversity for the sake of diversity, sacrificing meritocracy in the process. ■